

Introduction

Before his untimely death in April, 1971, Francis Story had projected a book on rebirth. He never completed it—indeed he never really began it—and thus gave his friends and readers one more reason to regret his passing. For he could have written an excellent work on the subject, one that would have combined his deep knowledge of Buddhist texts and literature with his extensive acquaintance with cases of the rebirth type in South Asia and of the peoples among whom these cases occur. And he would have illuminated the whole with his rigorous logic and lucid style of writing. I am sure the book he wanted to write would have greatly surpassed the one the reader now has before him. It is even possible that Francis Story will look down disapprovingly from the *deva* realms on the collection of his papers on rebirth which the Ven. Nyanaponika has so skillfully edited. For a number of the chapters included in this volume derive from mere drafts or field notes, which the author would certainly have developed further and revised if he had lived and had wished to publish them. I make this comment in an explanatory rather than an apologetic spirit. The friends of Francis Story have agreed that the importance of his contributions to the study of rebirth cases justify making them available to a wider circle of readers despite imperfections which he would have removed if he had lived longer. The reader should attribute any defects to those of us who wanted to see this work published rather than to the author, who had no chance to correct them himself.

Francis Story began to investigate cases of the rebirth type when he was living in Burma in the 1950s. At that period he started, at first almost casually, to jot down notes of cases he encountered. Gradually he became more systematic in his recording of the data he collected. In 1961 he accompanied me during my first trip of investigations in Sri Lanka, to which he had moved in 1957. Thereafter he joined me during every field trip I made in Sri Lanka until 1970. In addition, he helped me during two field trips in India and Thailand and he made trips of investigation by himself in India, Burma, and Thailand in the 1960s. At the time of his death he had some personal experience with most of the cases in Sri Lanka, Thailand, and Burma of which we then had any information. Many of them he had investigated entirely by himself.